Why Not Build Auth From Scratch?

The hidden costs and risks of custom authentication

The Illusion of Simplicity

It usually starts with a simple requirement: **"Just a login screen and a users table in the database."**

But modern authentication is rarely that simple. What starts as a basic login functionality quickly snowballs into a massive, tangled subsystem.

Developers constantly underestimate the complexity required to handle identity securely and reliably at scale.

The Hidden Complexities

Password Storage

You can't just save passwords. You need to implement salting, hashing (like bcrypt or Argon2), and handle password migration when algorithms become deprecated.

Session Management

Handling state securely across microservices requires managing JWTs, refresh tokens, revoking compromised sessions, and preventing CSRF attacks.

The "Edge" Cases

Account recovery, email verification, implementing Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA), and integrating Social Logins take massive engineering effort.

The Security Risks

- **Cryptographic Flaws:** Rolling your own crypto or implementing auth protocols incorrectly often leads to severe vulnerabilities.
- **Vulnerability to Attacks:** Custom systems are prime targets for brute-force attacks, credential stuffing, and injection flaws (OWASP Top 10).
- **Compliance Nightmares:** Meeting stringent regulatory requirements like GDPR, HIPAA, or SOC2 is extremely difficult with a homegrown auth system.
- **Total Liability:** If a breach occurs due to an auth flaw, the liability falls entirely on your development team, damaging company reputation.

Custom Auth vs. IAM

Building From Scratch

- ✕ Weeks or months of initial dev time
- ✕ High cost of ongoing maintenance
- ✕ Prone to security misconfigurations
- ✕ Adding features (SSO, MFA) is a massive project
- ✕ Distracts from core business logic

Using an IAM (Keycloak)

- ✓ Deploy and configure in minutes/hours
- ✓ Maintained by a dedicated security team
- ✓ Strict compliance with OIDC & SAML standards
- ✓ MFA, Social Login, and SSO built-in
- ✓ 100% focus on building your actual product

The Opportunity Cost

30%

of Initial Dev Time Wasted

Building what is already built.

Engineering teams often spend up to 30% of their initial project timeline just building and securing identity infrastructure.

That is valuable time and budget taken away from building the unique features that actually differentiate your core product in the market.

Don't Reinvent The Wheel

Identity is a Solved Problem.

Modern Identity and Access Management (IAM) solutions like Keycloak are designed specifically to handle the heavy lifting of security.

By offloading authentication to a dedicated, battle-tested server, you ensure enterprise-grade security while drastically accelerating your time-to-market.

Image Sources

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